

WTF is Perplexity?

The answer engine that cites its sources, the browser that does your errands, and the cloud agent that finishes the job. Perplexity went from search rival to agent company in a year. What it does, what it costs, the lawsuits, and whether it beats the free ones.

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The one-liner

Perplexity is an answer engine: ask a question, get a written answer with the sources cited, live from the web. It is the research seat in a solo founder's stack and the thing to reach for when a claim needs a receipt.

In 2026 it became more than that. Comet, its free browser, has an agent inside that fills forms, books and buys; Perplexity Computer, launched in February, is a cloud agent that takes a task and finishes it. The company that set out to replace Google now competes with every work agent in this series.

By the numbers — September 2026

~\$23B

valuation at the round that closed 9 January 2026, up from \$20B in September 2025; Nvidia was reported in August to be in talks above \$30B, not yet closed

~\$750M

annualised revenue by August 2026, from \$232M at the end of 2025 — and \$450M by March, a month after Computer launched

100M+

monthly users across search, Comet and Computer, per the CEO in April; the core search app alone around 30–45M

Feb 2026

Perplexity Computer launches: a cloud agent with usage-based pricing

18 Feb

2026: advertising dropped entirely, completing a retreat that began when it stopped taking new advertisers in October 2025

\$0 / \$20 / \$200

Free, Pro and Max per month; Enterprise Pro \$40 a seat and Enterprise Max \$325; Comet Plus \$5 for premium publisher content

2022

founded by Aravind Srinivas, Denis Yarats, Johnny Ho and Andy Konwinski

What it actually does

Search with sources — Every answer carries numbered citations you can open. The feature that made it, and still the reason to use it over a chat app for anything you will publish.

Pro Search and Research — Deeper multi-step searches, and a research mode that reads dozens of sources and writes a report. On Pro you pick the model: Claude, GPT, Gemini or Perplexity's own Sonar.

Spaces — Upload documents and search across them alongside the web; a research workspace per project.

Comet — A Chromium browser with an agent in the sidebar. Ask it to compare products across tabs, fill in a form, book a table, unsubscribe from twenty newsletters; it does it in your open session. Free since October 2025; iPhone since March.

Perplexity Computer — The agent: give it a task and it works in the cloud, browsing, building and delivering, billed by use on top of the plan. This is what tripled the revenue.

Sonar API and gateway — Perplexity's own models and a gateway to hosted open models (DeepSeek, Kimi, GLM, Nvidia's Nemotron) for developers who want sourced answers inside their products.

Distribution deals — Bundled free with Airtel plans in India, on Samsung TVs, and in a Microsoft 365 integration. Perplexity buys defaults rather than persuading users to switch.

What it costs

Plan	Price	What you get
Free	\$0	Unlimited standard search, a few Pro Searches a day, Spaces, Comet
Pro	\$20/mo	Unlimited Pro Search, model choice, Research, file uploads, a monthly usage credit
Max	\$200/mo	Everything, top models, full Comet agent and Computer allowances
Enterprise	\$40/seat, Max \$325	Team spaces, security, admin; about \$34 a seat billed annually
Comet Plus	\$5/mo	Access to premium publisher content, with revenue shared to publishers
Computer	Usage-based	Agent tasks billed on top of the plan

The free tier is a good search engine. Pro is the research seat. Max and Computer are for people who hand it work rather than questions, and the meter runs by the task.

Perplexity vs your chat app's deep research

	Perplexity Pro	Claude / ChatGPT deep research	Google
Citations	On every answer, by default	In research mode	AI overviews, links below
Model choice	Yes	The lab's own	Gemini
Agent	Comet in the browser, Computer in the cloud	Cowork, ChatGPT Work	Gemini Agent, Chrome
Price	\$20	Included in the \$20 plan you already pay	Free
Strength	Fast sourced answers, live web	Depth and reasoning on the same subscription	Reach, defaults

The honest question for most people: if you already pay \$20 for Claude or ChatGPT, their deep-research modes cover most of what Perplexity Pro does. Perplexity earns its own subscription when citations are the product, when you want to switch models per question, or when Comet's browser agent saves you real time every week.

The catches

- **The lawsuits.** Publishers including Dow Jones and the New York Post have sued over scraping and reproduction; Comet Plus and the publisher revenue share are the response. If courts go against AI search, the model changes. Not your problem as a user; a real one for the company.
- **The incumbents are copying it.** Google, Microsoft and OpenAI all now cite sources and ship browser agents. Perplexity's edge is being the purpose-built one, and that edge narrows every quarter.
- **Comet holds your sessions.** A browser agent acting in your logged-in tabs is powerful and is the same prompt-injection surface as every other agent with your credentials. Give it errands, not banking.
- **Usage pricing on Computer.** The plan is \$20; the agent is metered. Watch the first month.
- **Answers are only as good as the sources.** Citations show where a claim came from, not whether the source was right. Perplexity makes checking easy; it does not do it for you.

Who it is for

Yes — Anyone whose work involves finding and citing current information: writers, analysts, founders doing market research, students. Pro at \$20 if that is daily.

Not yet — Anyone already paying for Claude or ChatGPT who has not tried their deep-research mode. Try that first; add Perplexity if citations or Comet earn it.

No — Anyone who wants a generalist agent for their own apps and files (Cowork, ChatGPT Work) rather than the web.

Why it matters

Perplexity is the company that made "where did that come from?" a default expectation of AI, and then proved that an answer engine could turn into an agent company: a browser that acts, a cloud agent that finishes, and revenue that tripled in eight months when it did. It is also the clearest case study in fighting Google with defaults instead of persuasion. Whether that is enough against three trillion-dollar rivals copying every feature is the question its next round will price.

Glossary

Perplexity — AI answer engine and agent company, San Francisco, founded 2022. ~\$23B valuation.

Answer engine — Search that returns a written, cited answer rather than a list of links.

Pro Search — Perplexity's deeper multi-step search mode; limited on Free, unlimited on Pro.

Sonar — Perplexity's own model family and API.

Spaces — Project workspaces that search your uploaded documents alongside the web.

Comet — Perplexity's free Chromium browser with a built-in agent. Comet Plus is the \$5 publisher-content tier.

Perplexity Computer — The cloud agent launched February 2026; takes tasks, billed by usage.

Citation — A numbered link to the source of a claim; Perplexity's defining feature.

Default deal — Bundling with a carrier, device or suite so users get Perplexity without choosing it.

Liked this? Go deeper.

Perplexity is the research seat. Here is how to choose a model, and the rest of the stack.

GO DEEPER

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